Indeed, Modi's biggest success was that he made the mandate about himself and the high growth rate he had achieved in Gujarat, about rising incomes and the 'Gujarat model' of governance, a model whose grey edges remained surprisingly unchallenged till nearly the very end of the election campaign. He represented, in a sense, the 'audacity of hope'—a charismatic orator, a state chief minister who was spinning a dream for a positive future at a time when the country was burdened with negativism. Leaders emerge in a context—at a time of an economy in turmoil and a political class riddled with corruption, Modi was, as one senior Congress politician conceded, 'the right man at the right time with the right rhetoric'.

In the process, he was able to discard his own spotted legacy and that of his party. The 2002 post-Godhra riots and the fact that more than a thousand people died under his watch were simply not an issue in 2014 because Modi was able to artfully change the terms of the political discourse to a more 'inclusive' vision premised on effective governance. Or maybe that's how a majority of Indians preferred to see him—not as an ideologue of religious nationalism but as a tough, no-nonsense administrator.

Hindutva politics can never be disconnected from the Sangh Parivar's ethos and the RSS (Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh) is part of Modi's DNA, but there was a conscious attempt to keep any overtly religious appeal on the backburner. The RSS did fully throw itself into the campaign and their cadres were the BJP's last-mile warriors, especially in the crucial battleground of Uttar Pradesh. But this election wasn't going to be about building a Ram mandir in Ayodhya, unlike the 1991 and 1996 elections where the BJP made its first serious bid for power. It wasn't about a core ideological agenda that pushed for a uniform civil code or Article 370. Nor was this election going to be decided by communal polarization, unlike Modi's first win as Gujarat chief minister in 2002. That election was fought in the backdrop of riots and Modi's claim to be a Hindu Hriday Samrat (Emperor of Hindu Hearts). This election was fought in the context of an India itching for change and Modi being its principal agent of transformation.